deeply threatened. Facing the huge and increasing challenge of mass extinctions of species caused by the destruction of premium habitats, Myers argued that priorities had to be set to establish where to concentrate resources to conserve as many lifeforms as possible.

Defining hotspots

Initially, Myers identified ten hotspots crucial for conserving plant species that were endemic (did not grow anywhere else on Earth). By 2000, he had refined the concept to focus attention on regions that fulfilled two criteria: the area must contain at least 1,500 vascular plants (plants with roots, stems, and leaves) that were endemic, and it must have lost at least 70 percent of its primary vegetation (the plants that originally grew in the area). Conservation International, an environmental agency that uses Myers' concept to guide its efforts, now lists 36 such regions. Although they represent only 2.5 percent of Earth's land surface, they are home to nearly 60 percent of the planet's plant, amphibian, reptile, mammal, and bird species—and a high proportion of these species live only in their respective hotspot.

Most hotspots lie in the tropics or subtropics. The one facing the highest threat level is the Indo-Burma area in Southeast Asia. Only 5 percent of the original habitat remains, but its rivers, wetlands, and forests are vital for the conservation of mammals, birds, freshwater turtles, and fish. Animals unique to this area include the saola, a forest-dwelling mammal that is related to cattle but looks like an antelope; it was seen for the first time in 1992, in the Annamite Mountains of Vietnam. The endangered Irrawaddy dolphin is found along the coastlines of Southeast Asia and the islands of Indonesia. Other rare animals include Eld's deer, the fishing cat, and the giant ibis.